



# Indian Subcontinent

SEPARATED FROM the rest of Asia by the Himalayas, the Indian subcontinent is home to more than one-fifth of the world's population—almost 1.7 billion people. They have a long and complex history, form many different ethnic groups, speak a wide variety of languages, and worship many different gods. While some people in these countries are wealthy, many others live in poverty. Tensions between and within countries in this region have sometimes erupted in warfare. The Indian subcontinent is often affected by natural disasters, notably cyclones in the Bay of Bengal, and earthquakes and floods in Pakistan. However, India, the most heavily populated nation and once prone to famine, is now more than self-sufficient in food. All but Nepal and Bhutan were once ruled by the British, whose legacy can be seen in the common language of English, in some architecture, the vast railway system, and in sport—most notably cricket.

## MONSOON

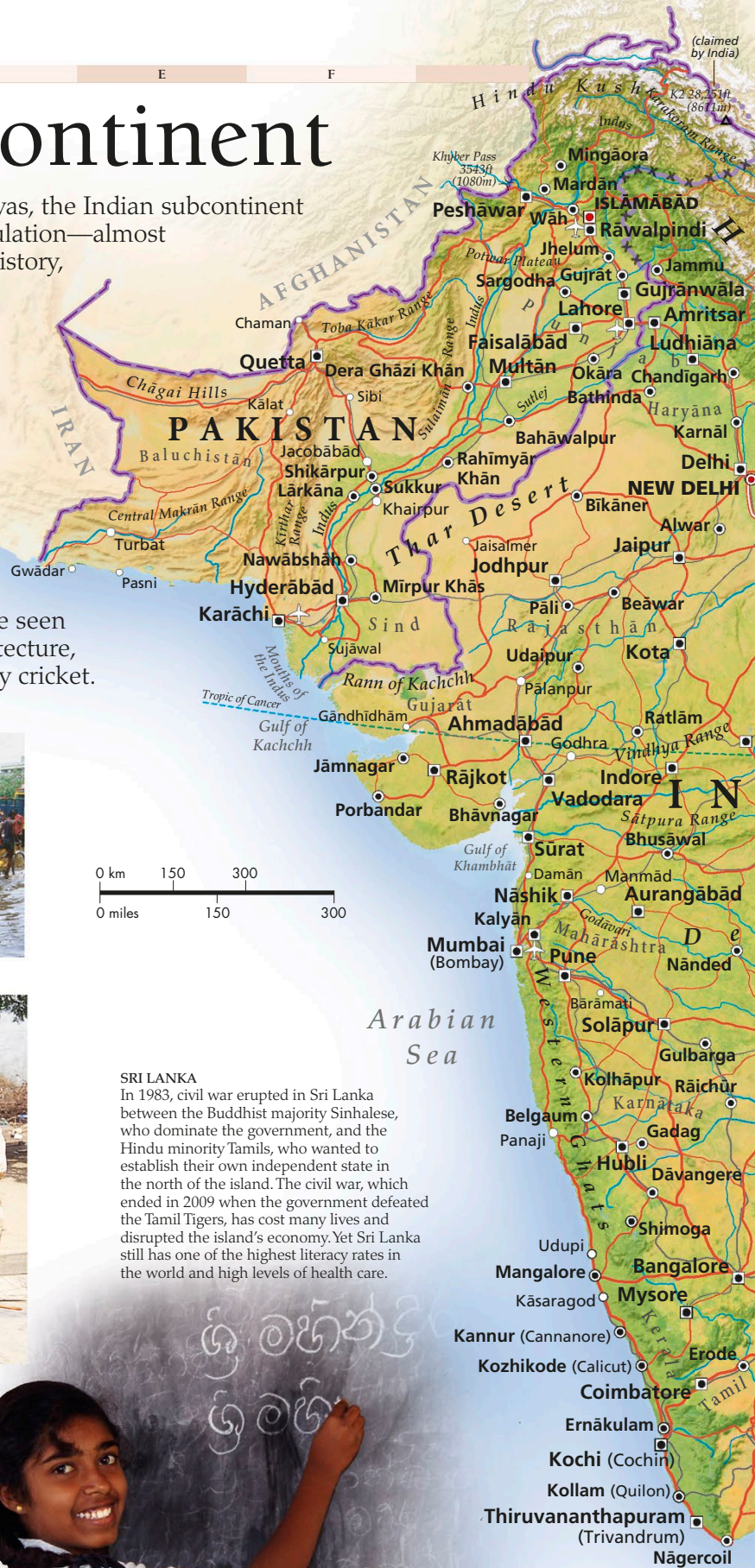
From May/June to September, warm, moist southerly winds sweep up from the Indian Ocean and the Bay of Bengal across the subcontinent. Once these winds meet dry land, moisture falls as monsoon rainfall. Although this irrigates the land and replenishes the water supply, it can also cause severe flooding.



## FAMILY LIFE IN PAKISTAN

Pakistanis have strong ties to their extended families, and often many generations live and work together in family-run businesses. Smaller family units, however, are becoming more common in urban areas. Although some women hold prominent positions in public and commercial life, such as Benazir Bhutto who was prime minister twice before she was assassinated in December 2007, most women do not work outside the home.

School child, Sri Lanka



## SRI LANKA

In 1983, civil war erupted in Sri Lanka between the Buddhist majority Sinhalese, who dominate the government, and the Hindu minority Tamils, who wanted to establish their own independent state in the north of the island. The civil war, which ended in 2009 when the government defeated the Tamil Tigers, has cost many lives and disrupted the island's economy. Yet Sri Lanka still has one of the highest literacy rates in the world and high levels of health care.